Thamesmead Town

NEWS BULLETIN 1/87

Issued by Thamesmead Town
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A lot of questions are being asked about what's going on in Thamesmead - and its clear its about time some of them were answered. We can't always tell you what you want to know but we can try and do our best so - here goes!*********.

Who's running Thamesmead? Is it TT, or the LRB?

Thamesmead Town (your Company) is running Thamesmead for you. But your landlord for the time being is the London Residuary Body (LRB). At the moment TT is only their agent for the area.

When will TT take over then?

Plans are well advanced to complete the transfer of business quickly, but no transfer date has been agreed. We are pressing for an early date.

We are hearing about repair charges being introduced- Why? and what for?

TT as a responsible landlord will undertake the statutory repairs. But, we feel that it is realistic to ask tenants to put right damage that they, their family or visitors cause to their homes - particularly where it has been caused by their negligence or deliberately. We do not think that it is fair that the neighbours should pay for such damage in their rents.

WHAT'S ALL THIS ABOUT SELLING TOWER BLOCKS - OR ANYTHING ELSE, FOR THAT MATTER?

TT has no plans REPEAT NO PLANS to sell Tower Blocks to anyone. When we take over, existing tenants will be able to exercise their Right to Buy. We anticipate that at the outset, most of the property sales will be in this category. In the longer term we intend to refurbish the older housing stock, some of which must be offered for sale to cover the cost of the work. We intend to give Thamesmead residents the first option to buy. However, the Company through housing associations and others intends to bring on stream rented housing equivalent to the quantity sold each year.

Will TT be trying to make a profit?

Our first priority is to look after our tenants, and second, to continue the development of the town. However, we must also balance our books, and if there are profits they will be ploughed back into Thamesmead. None of the profits can or will be paid to the Directors, the Constitution of the Company prohibits that absolutely.

What about rent arrears?

The LRB is owed some £412,000 in rent arrears. The Company intends to streamline its rent recovery action so that the outstanding amount is reduced. If tenants find themselves facing financial hardship they should contact the Housing Department as soon as they are able, so that alternative arrangements can be made.

Since April 1986, 120 possession orders and 48 warrants have been issued and 12 evictions have been carried out.

IMPORTANT NOTICE Some of you may have found out the hard way that insurance is worthwhile - you should insure the contents of your home against theft, damage, flood & fire. We can provide advice and guidance at the Information Centre at Harrow Manor Way. Write or call for information.

We know that Mr Thornton said rents wouldn't go up for a year - that takes us to this April - what happens then?

Under the Rent Act 1977, TT as a private landlord has to make an application to register a 'Fair Rent' for your accommodation. Once registered that rent applies for the next 2 years. You will be advised when the Company makes the application and you have the right to make representations to the Rent Officer. After the rents have been registered it will be for the Board of TT to implement the results of the rent review. Remember the Rent Officer, not the Company decides the 'Fair Rent' for the accommodation.

Why isn't more done about vandalism, rubbish dumping and graffiti?- What are you doing to help?

TT believes that the only way to tackle this problem is for everyone to work together. We shall be giving staff responsibility for defined housing areas. We intend to improve the way that the residential accommodation is both maintained and managed. But unfortunately very little can be done until we take over. Meanwhile, staff are being trained in their new duties. But tenants, especially parents can help as well, by having a word with those that cause the nuisance. After all, not only are these incidents costing the Company money, but they may well stop some urgent repairs being carried out.

The people who live here are often best placed to take immediate action on such problems - we will do all we can to help but cannot do it without you. If you see it happening - DO SOMETHING ABOUT IT.

We've heard there is a new "service charge" - what is that for?

These charges will be part of the 'Fair Rent' and are for the actual costs of services specifically provided to some tenants, such as heating, hot water, window, stair and hallway cleaning and communal lighting. The Company cannot charge what it likes - the Rent Officer decides what is right, not the Company

Will TT tenants still have the Right to Buy when the Company takes over?

Existing tenants "Right to Buy" is preserved when the Company takes over. New tenants will not enjoy the same statutory rights.

Will time in Thamesmead be counted towards discount for Right to Buy if someone moves off Thamesmead to a council house or flat?

The preservation of the Right to Buy only applies to property at Thamesmead. It will be for the new landlords to decide whether to allow a discount in these circumstances.

Why are you proposing to change the tenancy conditions so inside decorations are not done by the landlord any more?

We have been finding that more people prefer to do their own internal decorations. But, TT, will be arranging for provision of a service on request for those tenants who cannot do their own decorating nor have relatives or friends to help them. We feel that this will include not just some elderly people but also some people who are disabled or on low incomes who have not been entitled to full decorations in the past.

Our aim is to make sure that those who really do need help get it, and to involve the community in providing not just that help, but contact too.

The discontinuation of this service would be taken into account when the Rent Officer assess your rent.